

Pita Bread

The pocket is steam, trapped between two thin skins, on a surface hot enough to set them before the gas escapes. Reliable on a stone or a galley skillet. Twenty pitas for a crew of ten to twelve.

Yield: ~20 pitas (serves 10–12) Active: 40 min Total: 3 hr (incl. proof) Surface: 285°C (545°F) Bake: 2–4 min

INGREDIENTS

~20 PITAS AT 85G · WEIGHT & BAKER’S %

DOUGH

Bread flour (higher protein = better puff)	1000g	100%
Water, lukewarm (28–30°C)	640g	64%
Olive oil	30g	3%
Fine sea salt (after hydration)	20g	2%
Sugar (feed + browning)	15g	1.5%
Instant dried yeast (halve if cold-ferment)	8g	0.8%

THE RATIO — FLOUR = 100%
Water 64% · Oil 3% · Salt 2% · Sugar 1.5% · Yeast 0.8%. Below 60% water the pocket starves for steam; above ~68% it’s too slack to roll clean. 64% is the hand-rolled sweet spot. Rescale anything from this.

Kit: baking stone/steel or heavy cast-iron skillet / plancha · scale · rolling pin · bench scraper · 2 towels (keep pitas soft) · peel if using a stone

METHOD

- Mix.** Whisk 8g yeast + 15g sugar into 1000g flour. Add 640g warm water + 30g oil to a shaggy mass; rest 15 min — **hold the salt.**
- Salt + knead.** Add 20g salt, knead 8–10 min to a smooth, elastic, just-tacky dough (rough windowpane).

64% water + developed gluten = enough steam to inflate and skins strong + stretchy enough to hold it into one balloon. — McGee / Modernist Bread
- Bulk ferment.** Covered, 60–90 min at 20–24°C until doubled. (Make-ahead: halve yeast, cold-ferment 24–72 hr.)
- Divide + rest.** Scale ~20 × 85g balls. Rest covered 20–30 min. **Preheat the surface to max now** (stone: 45 min).

Balling tightens gluten; the rest lets it relax + re-align so it rolls even and won’t spring back. Even rolling is the #1 predictor of a clean pocket. — Reinhart / López-Alt
- Roll + 2nd rest.** Roll each to ~18 cm, **4–5 mm even**, turning a quarter per stroke. Rest the rounds 10 min, covered. Brush off loose flour.

Bake — two routes, 285°C surface

- Stone/steel (oven):** 275–290°C, top third. Slide a round on → balloons in **2–3 min**. Pull puffed + barely coloured.
- Skillet/plancha (galley):** dry, max heat, water skitters instantly. Round down ~30 sec → flip → **balloons 1–2 min**. Press stubborn spots with a folded towel.
- The skins must set faster than the steam leaks — only happens above ~230°C. Cast iron holds that heat, which is why the skillet works at sea. — McGee / Modernist*

Done: Fully **ballooned into a dome** (the pocket is the cue), set + dry, a few pale-gold blisters — **not browned hard.**

Keep soft: stack straight into a towel-lined bowl off the heat — trapped steam keeps them foldable. Pull at the dome, never at colour.

ELEVATION

TIER 1 — NO EXTRA TIME

- 20% whole wheat** — swap 200g flour, +20g water
- Nigella / sesame** — pressed into the round
- Za’atar-oil brush** — manakish-style finish

TIER 2 — WORTH IT (+15 MIN)

- Cold overnight ferment** — halve yeast, 24–72 hr fridge
- Milk + yogurt** — replace 150g water with yogurt
- Garlic-herb oil** — brushed warm on exit

TIER 3 — RESTAURANT

- Sourdough levain** — 200g levain, water ~100g
- Laffa / saj** — 28cm, ~2mm, on a domed plancha
- 80/20 bread + 00** — strength + stretch

TROUBLESHOOT

No pocket / flat	Surface not hot enough. Preheat longer; water must skitter instantly.
Uneven / blows a hole	Rolled uneven. 4–5 mm uniform, turn a quarter each stroke.
Springs back rolling	Gluten too tight. Rest balls 20–30 min, rounds 10 min more.
Tough, leathery	Overbaked / too dry. Pull at the dome; hold 64%; stack under towel.
Cracks when folded	Baked too long. Shorter bake; keep covered to steam-soften.
Acrid taste	Burnt bench flour. Brush rounds; wipe surface between bakes.

CHARTER PREP & STORAGE

Best route	Cold-ferment the dough; bake fresh on a hot skillet mid-charter — no deck oven.
Dough	3 d fridge, halved yeast, covered. Warm before rolling.
Divided balls	1 d fridge, oiled tray. Room temp before rolling.
Baked	2 d airtight RT. Re-warm in foil or a hot pan.
Frozen	2 mo, parchment between. Toast / pan-warm from frozen.
Never	Refrigerate baked pita — stales fast, goes leathery.